posted in Beijing who, on his own authority, suddenly conveyed to the Chinese that the deal was off the table.[89] In 1983, according to former foreign secretary Shyam Saran, India proposed a modification of the swap by proposing a deal in which 'India would retain the territory it claimed in the eastern sector while China would concede some additional territory in the western sector'. China showed interest but contingent on Mrs Gandhi visiting China. Mrs Gandhi apparently 'wanted to wait until after the general elections in 1985' before taking a final decision. With her death on 31 October 1984, the high-level swap initiative ended.[90]

What led to this thaw between 1979 and 1983? Delhi and Beijing were on opposite sides of the Cold War, and relations might have spiralled negatively. In fact, even though the basic alignments of India, China, the Soviets, and the US stayed in place until 1989, Delhi and Beijing tried to reduce their differences. As we will see in a later chapter, Delhi was preparing to reach out to Washington for economic reasons and a desire to avoid being too dependent on Moscow, especially after the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in December 1979. Improving relations with Beijing was a parallel track: Delhi needed a peaceful regional environment to deal with its internal economic and political problems (for example, separatism). Beijing made a similar calculation. It sought stability on its borders with the Soviets and wanted greater bargaining room with the US. Mending fences with Delhi would stabilize its western border and allow it to concentrate on its economy.

The first phase of border negotiations, 1981–1988

The thaw in relations led to eight rounds of border talks between 1981 and 1989 – talks that are often unfairly disparaged. These were the first set of serious negotiations on the border in twenty years, after the Nehru–Zhou summit of 1960 and the Officials' Report of 1961. While they failed to produce a breakthrough, they did bring greater clarity to the emerging views of the two sides – views that have largely endured. In this sense, they were